NINTENDO IN CONCERT:

AN ECONOMY OF EXCITEMENT AND NOSTALGIA

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As the name suggests, *Nintendo in Concert* boasts a repertoire of music from game company Nintendo's video games. For someone like me, who has little experience with 'high' art music, it was a familiar and reassuring word to read among other, more daunting titles such as "Chamber Recital" or "Brass Ensemble" in the Yong Siew Toh (YST) programme booklet (Yong Siew Toh Conservatory of Music 2023) . *Nintendo in Concert* has certainly stayed true to this – driven by a poignant, and yet not sad, nostalgia, it mobilizes symbols of childhood and the notion of video games to effuse music into a collective experience to be actively enjoyed.

Both within and outside performance, the concert strays from esoteric conventions of music and strips the concert experience to simply music and the people engaged in it. This impression was certainly produced in part by the din of conversations occurring both near the entrance to the hall as well as inside it – the attendees and musicians alike seemed to be simply catching up with each other. I, too, was not exempt: I ran into a friend and a classmate before the start of the show, who were attending in-between classes. The atmosphere was genial – it seemed like an occasion for music and merriment, not for a momentous performance of art, but simply a light-hearted appreciation. The e-booklet of the performance, too, reflected this: the pixelated font and bright colours, accompanied by images of popular 1990s-2000s video game icons (see Figure 1), already primes the audience to reminisce about simpler times of their childhood spent playing video games, or even watching TV shows with these characters.

The hall itself was more informal than I expected of a musical performance: there was no stage, only an arrangement of chairs facing each other, with some stands for sheet music and microphones (see Figure 2). The musicians filtered into the hall one by one, dressed casually with no discernible uniform, and were greeted by cheers (and video-taking) from their friends in the audience. There was no master of ceremony or conductor; instead, one of

the members of the ensemble took to the mic to introduce the event and the items. He jovially greeted the audience, and invited us to a “journey with Nintendo”.



Figure 1. The cover of the e-programme booklet.

The concert consisted of eight items and an encore. There were many instruments in the ensemble: chordophones (the piano, viola, violin and double bass), aerophones (the clarinet and saxophone) and membranophones (drums) were visible among other instruments at a first glance (see Figure 2; von Hornbostel and Sachs 1961).



Figure 2. The set-up of the concert.

The first item, *Dolphin Shoals* from *Mario Kart 8*, opened the show with a bang – quite literally, of the drum. The loud, bassy and upbeat start settles into a colourful melody. The tempo varies across sections: it is sometimes high and sometimes low, simulating the exhilarating feeling of racing in Mario Kart. The higher-tempo parts, which emphasize the saxophone, drew particular attention from the audience, who were undoubtedly recalling this track as players sped toward the end of this race.

The next item, *Comet Observatory* from *Super Mario Galaxy*, which begins in a slow and calm manner. The beat picks up in the next section as the drums begin playing, then once again settles into the relatively slower, smoother and softer tempo of the opening melody. The beat picks up again with the piano and the flute. The alternating rise and fall structure of the music induces a 'fluttery' feeling, juxtaposing the quick excitement of the game with the feeling of stability and safety the player experiences in-game at the observatory.

The next two items find their source in the famous *Legend of Zelda* games. The *Fairy Fountain* theme emphasises higher notes played on wind instruments and the piano. Interestingly, the drummer switches between instruments for this piece, moving to a set of bar chimes to accompany the chordophones. The introduction of the bar chimes give a sparkly and bright texture to the melody, while the repetitive sound pulls the audience in. The performance then moves into the main theme of *Breath of the Wild*, which plays at a moderate tempo but fills the hall with its flourishing sounds. The drummist uses a red Tang drum to incorporate deep and expansive notes into the melody, underscoring the 'open-world' affect that this theme brings out.

These relatively slower melodies are followed by upbeat songs. *K. K. Bossa*'s theme from *Animal Crossing: New Horizons* is short and light, with an easy and catchy beat, making it a very fun tune to bob your head and shake your foot to. *Kirby Superstar*'s *Gourmet Race* follows: its adrenaline-inducing heavy bass pushes the loudness and quick tempo of the song. The addition of the sound of an idiophone (likely the claves) that punctuate the repetitive beat gives the song a bubbly effect.

The next item was a mashup of music heard in the Generation 3 Pokémon games. It was one of the songs I was looking forward to the most, owing to hours spent playing these games as a young girl. My personal nostalgia was layered with a collective nostalgia as the acting emcee (see Figure 3), who had so far introduced all the other pieces through their games, instead shared a story of the meaning of this medley to the JDN Ensemble – it was one of the first songs they had composed and performed when it was a group of only three people; they now had the pleasure of performing it with over fifteen members. The medley began with slower world music from the games which can be heard in the player's hometown and those in the cities, and switches suddenly to battle music across six sections. The experience of listening to this medley is also quite different from the rest of the set because it

simulates for someone familiar with Pokémon music the in-game journey and experience of playing. Though pieces like *Dolphin Shoals* and *Gourmet Race* can make us remember particular racecourses and the *Breath of the Wild* theme elicits the journey of Link, *Pokémon mashup* samples music from across locations in the game, recreating the feeling of the whole game as we traverse across sections of the song.



Figure 3. The emcee and (presumably) founder of the JDN Party Quest Ensemble.

The last item on the official set was the ending theme from *Super Mario World*. Despite its slow tempo during the piano solos, the song is bubbly and upbeat as the melody flows into faster-paced sections. This combination of relatively slower tempo but bubbly texture of music lends itself to the feeling of nostalgia that, as I have demonstrated, permeated the entire concert experience; indeed, it took on a bit of pathos as I realised we have come to the end of the show. However, the rest of the audience clearly disagreed: there were chants for an encore, which the ensemble graciously accepted. Surprisingly, they did not

play a piece they had already performed, and the ease with which they began playing made me wonder if the encore was planned. *Lifelight* from *Super Smash Bros Ultimate* was an upbeat and had a flowing melody, which made it a perfect end to the concert. After the emcee announced the close of the show, the drummer played an outro for the audience as we left the hall.

For me, the music experience was infused with a deep nostalgia, belied by fast and upbeat music that accompanies child-like excitement and the remembered adrenaline of playing video games. The concept of the concert was, of course, pivoted on this nostalgic and exciting relic of video games that decorated our childhoods – these encoded cultural symbols were the language the performers conveyed their message through (see Figure 4). As the emcee said in the introduction to *Gourmet Race*, the choice of music dips into "pop culture references to ride the hype train".



Figure 4. "Where is Music?" (Ng 2023; Laszlo 1968).

The recognition of these embedded symbols reverts one to their younger days, and in doing so, strips the performance of any esotericism that may have accompanied the traditional convention of a 'concert'. Both the audience and performers treated the music as a vehicle of enjoyment, and the familiarity all the participants had with these musical pieces only served to make its experience an active pursuit – the audience and musicians bobbed their heads together and cheered for their favourite parts as the songs played, rather than quietly enjoy the music and politely clap only when the piece ended. The call of the music back to one's childhood, through the economy of nostalgic and yet exciting symbols of video games, drives the genial and casual interaction of all the participants in how they engage with the music.

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